in the world, and they traditionally have controlled household budgets and many family decisions. Moreover, as the *Financial Times*'s Klein notes, more than half the growth in Japanese workers since 2003 has come from women entering the labor force, even as the overall population has shrunk. Prime Minister Abe's "womenomics" policy seeks to increase this number even more, as well as to break the glass ceiling in executive suites. Though no one would claim that Japan is yet close to real gender equality, society is slowly changing.

In education, Japanese students once again scored near the top of the OECD's global math, reading, and science rankings in 2015, ranking second after Singapore, surrendering the top spot they had held for years.[11] Americans, by contrast, scored significantly lower, thirty-sixth in math and twenty-fourth in reading, despite spending close to 30 percent more per student than Japan.[12] Meanwhile, Japan's unemployment rate is below 3.5 percent, which partly represents demographic decline but also the strong work ethic and expectation that able-bodied citizens will be in the labor force. Sixty-six percent of Japanese age fifteen to seventy-four were employed, according to the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, while 63 percent of Americans age sixteen or older held a job, according to the US Department of Labor, a number that has been dropping steadily since 2007.[13]

Japan's public health picture is also brighter than America's and Europe's. While there are numerous factors that could be measured, a few stand out. Japan ranks as the least obese developed country according to the OECD, while America is number one.[14] Moreover, whereas Denmark, France, Austria, Belgium, Norway, and America have the six highest cancer rates in the world, according to the World Cancer Research Fund, Japan ranks forty-eighth for cancer.[15] The country had a negligible number of AIDS cases, only 7,658 by 2014, compared to the United States, which recorded 1,216,917 cases since the 1980s.[16] While amphetamines have been a problem in some of Japan's major cities, the country has nothing like the opioid epidemic sweeping the United States. Even areas where Japan was among the worst in the developed world, as in suicides, it is making progress. The number of